Masking

In short

Hiding natural traits to fit in is called masking, and many neurodivergent people do it. It’s very tiring and can lead to burnout. Don’t judge habits like fidgeting, and focus on the quality of someone’s work.

Overview

Masking is when neurodivergent people hide their natural traits to fit in. It's often a constant performance to meet social expectations. It's like wearing a mask to hide things like stimming or social anxiety. Here are a few reasons why it's a challenge:

- It's very draining to do this all day
- It'll often lead to burnout and exhaustion
- It's hard for others to see when someone's struggling
- It stops people from being their true selves

You can help to create a more inclusive space where everyone feels safe enough to take their mask off, whether they choose to or not:

- Don't judge habits like avoiding eye contact or fidgeting
- Focus on work quality rather than how someone is socialising when assessing their performance
- Make it okay for everyone to talk about their needs
- Respect that everyone has different ways of working

Useful links

- National Autistic Society: Masking
- British Psychological Society: Dropping the mask takes two